

Chapter Nine

The Wrong Kind of Help

By morning, everyone in the building knew something had happened in apartment 4B.

Not the truth.

Never the truth.

Only the building version of it.

A door had been broken. Police had come. A man had shouted in the hallway. Claire had left with a bag and her sister, face turned down as if shame were something she needed to hide from the neighbors instead of something that belonged to him.

By ten o'clock, the story had already changed shape.

Nora heard pieces of it through the walls and from the stairwell.

"She always seemed quiet."

"I thought they were just arguing."

"He was polite when I saw him."

"You never know what happens in people's homes."

That last one made Nora pause with her hand on the kettle.

You never know what happens in people's homes.

The sentence was meant to sound wise. Sad, maybe. But it made something bitter rise in her throat.

People said that after.

After the shouting.

After the bruises.

After the police.

After the person suffering had already learned that walls were not only barriers, but witnesses with no mouths.

Nora turned off the kettle before it boiled.

Her apartment was quiet, but not peaceful. Adam had gone home just after midnight. Maya had called once before bed and made Nora promise to text if the pressure returned. Nora had promised.

She had meant it.

But promises had begun to feel fragile in her hands.

She moved through the morning slowly, carrying the afterimage of Claire's living room.

The cracked phone beneath the coffee table.

The lamp breaking.

The man's voice saying, Don't make me the villain.

That sentence would not leave her.

It was so ordinary. So obscene in its ordinariness. As if the worst thing that could happen was not Claire being hurt, but him being seen incorrectly.

Nora stood at the kitchen sink and looked at the wall between her apartment and Claire's.

Nothing came through it now.

No fear.

No shouting.

No emotional pressure.

Only silence.

But silence had become suspicious too.

At 11:16, someone knocked.

Nora startled so hard she almost dropped her mug.

The knock came again.

Not inside her.

At the door.

She crossed the apartment carefully and looked through the peephole.

Claire stood in the hallway.

For a moment, Nora did not move.

Claire wore the same cardigan from the night before under a long coat. Her hair was damp from rain. The red mark on her cheek had faded into something duller, easier to miss if a person wanted to miss it. She held her keys in one hand and a cardboard box in the other.

Nora opened the door.

“Hi,” Claire said.

“Hi.”

The word felt too small for what lay between them.

Claire glanced toward apartment 4B. “I’m just picking up some things. My sister is downstairs waiting.”

Nora nodded. “Okay.”

“I wanted to ask...” Claire stopped, eyes moving over Nora’s face. “Did the police talk to you again?”

“No.”

“Good.”

The answer surprised Nora.

Claire looked down at the box. “I mean, I don’t want this to become bigger than it already is.”

Nora gripped the edge of the door.

Bigger.

There were words people used when they were still afraid of naming the size of a thing.

Bigger.

Messy.

Complicated.

Private.

Nora knew she should be careful. She knew the rules. Useful without invading. Private pain stayed private unless there was danger.

But Claire was standing in front of her with a fading mark on her cheek and a box too small to hold everything she might need if she never came back.

“He hurt you,” Nora said.

Claire’s face closed.

Immediately.

Nora felt it happen like a door slamming.

“I’m sorry,” Nora added quickly. “I just mean—”

“You don’t know what happened.”

The injustice of that almost knocked the breath out of her.

Because Nora did know.

She knew Claire’s cheek had burned before the jump fully settled. She knew Claire had calculated the distance to the door. She knew the way fear had settled into her body with practice, not surprise.

But Claire was right too.

Nora had no right to know.

“I heard enough,” Nora said.

Claire's eyes sharpened. "Did you?"

Nora fell silent.

Claire looked down the hall, then back at Nora. Her voice lowered.

"You said my name."

Nora's stomach tightened.

"Last night," Claire continued. "When you were on the floor. I heard you say my name."

Nora tried to answer.

Nothing came.

Claire's grip tightened around the box. "Your fiancé said it was from the mailboxes."

"It might have been."

"That's not an answer."

No.

It was not.

Nora looked at the floor.

Claire gave a short, humorless laugh. "You know what's strange? Last night, before the police came, I felt like someone was watching me."

Nora went cold.

"Not him," Claire said. "Someone else. Like I wasn't alone in my own head."

Nora's mouth went dry.

Claire stared at her. "That sounds insane, right?"

Nora whispered, "No."

Claire stepped back.

The movement was small.

It hurt anyway.

“What does that mean?” Claire asked.

“It means...” Nora swallowed. “It means I believe you.”

“I didn’t ask you to believe me.”

The words landed harder than they should have.

Claire’s eyes were wet now, but angry too. Anger looked good on her. Alive. Nora wished she could feel only relief at seeing it.

“You looked at me last night like you knew everything,” Claire said. “When I came to your door, you looked guilty. Not scared. Guilty.”

“I was scared.”

“You were guilty.”

Nora could not deny it.

Claire’s voice trembled. “Do you know what that felt like? To have a stranger look at me like my life was already open in front of her?”

“I’m not a stranger,” Nora said, then hated herself for it.

Claire’s face hardened.

“Yes,” she said. “You are.”

The hallway seemed to narrow.

Nora heard a door open somewhere below. Footsteps. A cough. The building continuing around them, hungry for fragments.

Claire shifted the box against her hip. “Thank you for calling the police. I mean that. But whatever you think you know about me, keep it to yourself.”

“I only wanted to help.”

“I know.”

There was no softness in the answer.

That was what made it devastating.

Claire knew Nora wanted to help.

It did not erase the violation.

“I’m sorry,” Nora said.

Claire looked at her for a long moment.

Then she said, “People always say that after they’ve seen too much.”

She turned and walked back to 4B.

Nora stood in her doorway, unable to move.

A few seconds later, Claire unlocked her apartment and disappeared inside.

The door closed behind her.

Nora remained in the hall.

She had helped.

Claire was alive. Claire had left. Claire’s sister was downstairs. The man was not there.

Nora had helped.

So why did she feel like she had done something wrong?

Because she had.

Because she had not.

Because both could be true, and the unfairness of that made her want to scream.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket.

Adam.

She answered without thinking.

“Hi,” he said. “Checking in.”

Nora leaned against the doorframe. “Claire came by.”

Adam went quiet. “What happened?”

“She knows.”

“She knows what?”

“That something happened. With me. During the jump.” Nora closed her eyes. “She said she felt watched.”

Adam exhaled slowly.

“She’s angry,” Nora said.

“She has a right to be.”

The words cut.

Nora opened her eyes.

“I know.”

“I didn’t mean it like—”

“No. You did. And you’re right.”

“Nora.”

“She said I’m a stranger.”

Adam said nothing.

Nora laughed once, but there was no humor in it. “That’s the part that got me. I was inside her body. I felt her fear. I know the exact sound her lamp made when it broke. And she’s right. I’m still a stranger.”

Adam’s voice softened. “Knowing someone’s pain isn’t the same as knowing them.”

Nora hated him for saying it gently.

She hated him because it was true.

“I don’t know what I’m supposed to do with this,” she said. “If I know someone is in danger and I act, I’m invasive. If I don’t act, I’m cruel. If I tell the truth, I sound unstable. If I lie, I become exactly the kind of person everyone already thinks I am.”

“What kind of person is that?”

Nora looked toward Claire’s door.

“Too much,” she said.

The answer came from somewhere old.

Not from Claire.

Not from the jumps.

From childhood bedrooms and brothers who loved her but rolled their eyes when she cried too long. From Daniel saying, “Nora, it’s not that deep.” From Luis telling her, “You always make things dramatic,” then hugging her later like the wound had already closed because he was no longer uncomfortable.

From every moment she had learned to translate feeling into something smaller before offering it to other people.

Adam was quiet.

When he spoke, his voice had changed.

“Who told you that?”

Nora swallowed.

“No one.”

“Nora.”

“Everyone. A little.”

She could hear Adam breathing on the other end.

“I don’t think you’re too much,” he said.

The tenderness almost undid her.

But tenderness, lately, was another thing she did not know how to trust.

“You think I’m scared.”

“You are scared.”

“You think I make patterns out of pain.”

“I think everyone does.”

“But when I do it, people get hurt.”

Adam did not answer quickly enough.

Nora smiled bitterly, though he could not see it.

“There it is.”

“That’s not fair,” he said.

“I know. Nothing is.”

She ended the call before he could respond.

It was cruel.

She knew that.

She did it anyway.

Then she stood in the hallway with the dead phone in her hand and felt the shape of the morning close around her.

Claire’s door opened again.

Nora straightened.

Claire stepped out carrying the box. Her eyes were red, but her face had become calm in the way people became calm when they had no energy left for expression.

Nora moved aside.

Claire walked past her toward the stairs.

Then stopped.

For a second, Nora thought she might say something forgiving.

Instead, Claire said, “I hope whatever is wrong with you gets better.”

The words were not meant as cruelty.

That somehow made them worse.

Claire continued down the stairs.

Nora watched until she disappeared.

Then she went back into her apartment and closed the door.

Inside, the silence waited.

Nora set her phone on the table.

It buzzed almost immediately.

Adam calling back.

She let it ring.

Then Maya.

She let that ring too.

Then her mother.

Nora stared at the screen.

Her mother again.

For days, she had avoided that voicemail. The old world had been knocking, politely at first, then with increasing impatience.

This time, Nora answered.

“Mom?”

“Nora.” Her mother’s voice came sharp with relief, then sharper with irritation because relief embarrassed her. “Finally. I’ve been calling you.”

“I know. I’m sorry.”

“Are you sick?”

“No.”

“Then why do you sound sick?”

Nora closed her eyes.

“I’m tired.”

“You’re always tired. That’s what happens when you don’t sleep properly. Your brother said he saw Adam yesterday and Adam looked worried.”

Of course.

Her family worked like that. Information moved through them sideways, never directly, always arriving dressed as concern.

“Which brother?” Nora asked.

“Luis.”

Nora rubbed her forehead. “I’m fine.”

Her mother made a sound that meant she did not believe her but would accept the lie temporarily.

“Your brothers are coming Sunday,” she said. “Dinner here. You and Adam should come.”

“I don’t know if—”

“Nora.”

There it was.

The tone that turned refusal into disobedience.

“We haven’t all been together in weeks,” her mother continued.
“Daniel is bringing the boys. Luis says he might have news. I already told Adam.”

Nora opened her eyes.

“You called Adam?”

“He answers his phone.”

The sentence was small.

It still struck.

Nora’s voice cooled. “I said I’m tired.”

“And I am your mother. I know when tired means hiding.”

Nora gripped the back of a chair.

Hiding.

Everyone had a word for her now.

Scared.

Dramatic.

Too much.

Hiding.

“Mom, I can’t do this today.”

“Do what?”

“Be discussed like a family problem.”

Silence.

Then her mother sighed.

“Nora, nobody is discussing you.”

That was a lie. Maybe not intentional. But a lie all the same.

“I have to go,” Nora said.

“Nora—”

She ended the call.

Then immediately hated herself.

Her phone buzzed again.

A message from her mother.

Sunday. 6 p.m. Come eat. Bring Adam. Don’t isolate yourself.

Nora stared at the words.

Don’t isolate yourself.

People said that as if isolation were always a locked room someone chose from the inside. As if sometimes the world did not become so loud, so full of other people’s needs and judgments and weather, that closing the door felt like the only way to keep breathing.

She placed the phone face down.

The apartment seemed to pulse around her.

Too quiet.

Too full.

Her head began to ache.

Not pressure.

Not exactly.

Something thinner.

A thread pulling tight behind her eyes.

Nora stood very still.

“No,” she whispered.

The thread trembled.

From somewhere beyond the apartment, someone laughed.

From another direction, a baby cried.

A pipe knocked.

A door closed.

Lives stacked around her.

Walls full of weather.

Nora pressed both palms to her eyes.

“Not now.”

The thread loosened.

For one hopeful second, she thought it had passed.

Then came a knock.

Again, real this time.

At the door.

Nora froze.

She did not move.

The knock came again, softer.

“Nora?”

Maya.

Nora’s chest hurt.

She crossed the room and opened the door.

Maya stood in the hallway holding a paper bag.

“I brought bread,” she said, then looked at Nora’s face. “And apparently arrived in the middle of something.”

Nora wanted to laugh.

She wanted to collapse.

She wanted to tell Maya everything: Claire's anger, Adam's truth, her mother's call, the old ache of being too much and not enough in the same body.

Instead she said, "I hung up on Adam."

Maya nodded slowly. "Okay."

"And my mother."

"Less shocking."

Nora gave a broken laugh.

Maya stepped closer. "Can I come in?"

Nora moved aside.

Maya entered and set the bread on the table. She looked toward the shared wall with Claire's apartment, then back at Nora.

"Adam told me Claire came by."

"Of course he did."

"He was worried."

"Everyone is worried."

"Yes," Maya said. "That is what happens when someone you love starts disappearing into strangers."

Nora flinched.

Maya saw it.

"I'm not saying that to hurt you."

"It still hurt."

"I know."

The honesty between them was still new enough to feel dangerous.

Maya sat at the table.

Nora remained standing.

For a while, neither spoke.

Then Maya said, "Tell me what happened."

Nora looked away. "Claire said I made her feel watched."

Maya's expression changed, but she did not interrupt.

"She thanked me for calling the police. Then she told me to keep whatever I think I know to myself." Nora's throat tightened. "And she was right."

Maya was quiet.

"I helped her," Nora said. "But I also violated her. I didn't choose it, but it still happened through me. How am I supposed to live with that?"

Maya looked down at her hands.

"You may have to live with not being innocent," she said.

Nora stared at her.

Maya's eyes were gentle, but the sentence was not.

"What does that mean?"

"It means maybe you don't get to be only the victim of this thing. Maybe sometimes you are also the person carrying harm, even if you didn't ask to carry it."

Nora stepped back.

The words entered her like cold water.

"That's unfair."

"I know."

"No, Maya. That's unfair."

Maya stood slowly. “Yes. It is.”

“I didn’t choose this.”

“I know.”

“Then why do I have to be responsible for it?”

“Because it is happening through you.”

Nora shook her head.

She could not bear the fairness of it.

She could not bear the cruelty of it.

Maya’s voice softened. “Nora, I love you. But if this thing puts you inside people, then what you do afterward matters. Even when the beginning wasn’t your fault.”

Nora turned away.

Her eyes burned.

“I wish you would just comfort me.”

“I know.”

The answer broke something.

Nora covered her face with both hands.

For a moment, she was a child again, surrounded by people who loved her but did not know how to stand inside the size of her feelings. Only this was worse because Maya did know. Maya had always known.

And Maya was still not making it smaller.

Maya came closer, stopping just short of touching her.

“I can comfort you and tell you the truth,” she said.

Nora laughed through tears. “I hate that.”

“I know.”

This time, the words held warmth.

Nora lowered her hands.

Maya was crying too.

Not much. Just enough.

“I don’t want to lose myself,” Nora whispered.

Maya’s face shifted.

There it was.

The real sentence beneath all the others.

Maya reached for her slowly.

Nora let her.

The hug was careful at first. Then Nora folded into it, and Maya held her like someone holding a person on the edge of deep water.

For once, no jump came.

No pressure.

No door.

Only Maya’s arms and Nora’s own grief, which was terrible but at least belonged to her.

After a while, Maya said, “Call Adam back.”

Nora groaned into her shoulder.

“I know.”

“And your mother.”

“No.”

Maya almost laughed. “Fine. One impossible thing at a time.”

Nora pulled back and wiped her face.

Maya handed her the paper bag. “Eat bread first. Then apologize.”

“Is that your medical advice?”

“It is sister advice.”

The word sister settled between them.

Still tender.

Still real.

Nora took the bread.

For a few minutes, they stood in the kitchen tearing pieces from the loaf with their hands, eating without plates.

It was the most ordinary thing Nora had done in days.

Then her phone buzzed again.

This time, she picked it up.

Adam.

She answered.

“I’m sorry,” she said before he could speak.

Adam exhaled.

On the other end of the line, there was relief.

And hurt.

And love.

Nora could not feel them inside her body this time.

She only heard them in his silence.

That was enough.

“I’m here,” she said.

Maya stood beside her, close but not too close.

Adam's voice came quietly through the phone.

"So am I."

Nora closed her eyes.

For now, no doors opened.

For now, no one else's life pulled her away.

For now, the injustice remained exactly what it was.

Unfixed.

Unfair.

Unavoidable.

And still, somehow, survivable.